

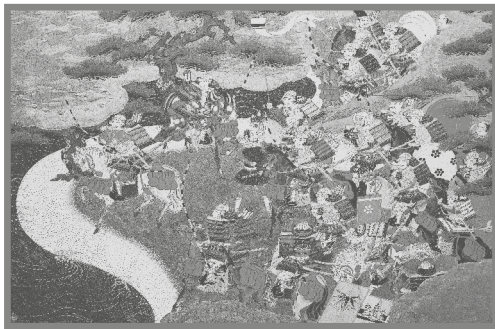
the Kyoto-based bureaucrats and the regional nobility, the samurai, who assumed a dominant role in local government. The Kyoto court appointed the most talented samurai as governors (*zuryō*), both to bind them to the imperial government and to prevent them from building their own power bases. However, the samurai developed loyalty to their extended family, or clan, and its leader rather than to the emperor, and fought one another from their power bases in the provinces. The Minamoto and Taira clans engaged in a series of these struggles which culminated in the Genpei War, during which the Taira were utterly crushed.

The shogunate

Following his victory, clan leader Minamoto Yoritomo established a parallel government based at Kamakura, about 250 miles east of Kyoto. Other clan chieftains became his vassals or *gokenin*, and he dispatched military estate governors to cement his control over the provinces. In 1192, Yoritomo accepted from the emperor the title of shogun, becoming the de facto military ruler of Japan.

Over the following centuries, the emperors made periodic vain attempts to reassert authority over the shogunate, but the shoguns in turn could not maintain control of the samurai and their warlords, who controlled their areas and fought among themselves. Japan dissolved into a patchwork of military warlords or *daimyo*, each with its own power base and retinue of samurai warriors.

Establishment of the office of shogun, which had seemed to offer Japan stability in 1192, ultimately led to the Sengoku, a civil war lasting almost 150 years. This war ended with the reunification of Japan under the new shogunate of Tokugawa in 1603. ■



At the time of the Genpei Wars the Samurai fought as mounted bowmen, but by the 15th century the sword, in particular the long-bladed *katana*, had become their principal weapon.



Minamoto Yoritomo

A descendant of the royal emperor Seiwa, Yoritomo was the heir of the Minamoto clan, which had been crushed by the Taira clan after a civil war in 1159. After the war, the now orphaned Yoritomo was exiled to Hirugashima, an island in Izu province. Here he remained for 20 years before issuing a call to arms and rising up against the Taira. He established a headquarters in Kamakura, from which he began to organize the warlords and samurai into an independent government.

A decisive victory over the Taira in 1185 sealed Yoritomo's military success, and he emerged the undisputed leader of Japan.

Yoritomo developed policies to relieve the strain between the military lords and the court aristocrats, and set up an administrative network that soon took over as the central government, but much of the remainder of his life was spent in suppressing those clans who had not accepted Minamoto dominance.